



Artificial Intelligence (AI) Acceptable Use Guidelines

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Southwest Wisconsin Technical College (Southwest Tech) is committed to providing a safe and secure environment for its employees, students, and partners, including the College's responsible use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools and resources. AI tools and resources have transformative potential to impact the College business and the larger industries in which the College operates. Southwest Tech has an interest in staying well informed and championing advances in technology; including acting responsibly when using AI and ensuring information and systems are not compromised. AI tools and resources are wide-ranging, and the general nature of this policy and guidelines apply across all AI tools.

These guidelines have been created to assist in determining the acceptable and unacceptable use of AI through a common understanding of the use of AI to support Southwest Tech's efforts to 1) maintain data and privacy security; 2) protect intellectual property rights; and 3) ensure accuracy. Given that generative AI tools learn based on input information, any information you add to the tool becomes part of the tool to be used by all other users. For this reason, it is extremely important to understand the tools and use responsibly.

1.0 – SCOPE

1.1 Involved Persons

This policy applies to employees, students, vendors, consultants, or volunteers producing work for the college. This policy also applies to board members, authorized contractors, vendors, guests, and other authorized users who access College technology and AI systems.

1.2 Involved Systems

These guidelines apply to equipment owned or leased by Southwest Tech, the Southwest Tech Foundation, and the Southwest Tech Real Estate Foundation. This applies to the use of any third-party or publicly available generative AI tools (as well as versions of the tool), including but not limited to ChatGPT, Google Gemini, DALL-E, Midjourney, Microsoft Copilot, AI meeting recording bots (both video and transcription) or similar applications that mimic human intelligence to generate answers, work product or perform certain tasks. AI systems and data are owned and controlled by the college. Access is a privilege granted for college-related activities.

1.3 AI Tool Approval

All AI tools, platforms, and plugins must be formally reviewed and approved by the AI Council before use with college, student, employee data. Academic requests will also be considered by the Academic Council. Unlisted tools are considered unapproved and may not be used. Any academic concerns or questions will also be addressed by the Academic Council.

1.4 AI Tool Inventory

The college will maintain a current inventory of all approved AI tools and versions. Employees must consult this inventory on the AI Hub site before deploying any AI solution.

2.0 – STANDARDS AND GUIDELINES

Acceptable Use:

- Use of AI tools and resources should be limited to business-related purposes and in-line with regulatory, compliance, and data privacy controls of the College.
- AI tools and resources must be used in compliance with all applicable laws and regulations, including data protection and privacy laws.
- All AI activities must comply with privacy laws, data protection regulations, intellectual property rights, and equal opportunity principles, including FERPA, HIPAA, PCI, and GDPR.
- AI use must comply with all college policies, procedures, codes of conduct, and relevant licenses or contractual commitments.
- Southwest Tech reserves the right to review and monitor AI usage, prompts, and outputs for security, compliance, investigation, and risk-management purposes, in accordance with applicable privacy laws and internal policies.
- AI access will only be granted after the completion of Southwest Tech-based AI training and signing the AI policy, agreeing to its terms and conditions.

Expectations:

- Use as an enhancement tool but understand AI is not a substitute for human judgment and creativity. Carefully review any work product generated by AI to ensure its accuracy, proofing and customization (if any). Cite AI when necessary. Be aware of bias in AI responses.
- AI tools may not be used as the sole decision-maker for academic evaluation, grading, admissions, financial aid, disciplinary actions, employment decisions, or other determinations that materially impact individuals.
- As you are ultimately responsible for content generated by AI, make sure you understand the basis of the AI tool you use, including its sources of data and any restrictions (date limitations on data, bias, false answers, stale information, copyrights of others, etc.).
- As a general rule, **treat any information you input into publicly available AI tools as if it could potentially become public**, regardless of privacy settings. **Do not enter any confidential,**

sensitive, or proprietary information related to Southwest Tech into AI platforms that are not institutionally approved.

- **Approved Exceptions:**

Microsoft Copilot and Anthology Copilot Embedded AI are the **only approved tools for processing confidential or proprietary Southwest Tech data**, as they are deployed within a secure, enterprise-grade environment that complies with our institutional data protection standards.

- When working with third-party vendors, discuss expectations regarding their use of AI, and ensure contract language aligns.
- Employees are responsible for ensuring use of AI tools and resources are in compliance with these standards and guidelines and any other relevant policies or procedures, including but not limited to the Acceptable Use of IT Resources Policy.
- All employees must be aware of their responsibilities for protecting confidential and restricted data or information, including but not limited to that related to donors, students, employees, and the college in general, and must take all necessary steps to safeguard the privacy and security of this information when using AI tools and resources.
- Managers and supervisors are responsible for ensuring their teams are aware of and comply with this policy. Violations of this policy must be reported to the Executive Director of Information Technology Services and/or Human Resources.
- AI systems must be explainable and transparent with rationale shared for how AI decisions are made. Grading decisions remain instructor-determined with human judgment.
- Work products created using AI technologies must be accessible to all users, including those with disabilities, and comply with WCAG 2.1AA guidelines. If not accessible, the owner of the work product is responsible for making the product digitally accessible.
- Access to AI systems and associated data will be restricted to authorized individuals with legitimate purposes.
- AI tools may not be used with data classified as Restricted or Confidential, including but not limited to student education records (FERPA), personally identifiable information (PII), protected health information (PHI / HIPAA), employee records, authentication credentials, security configurations, or non-public contract terms. Only public, anonymized, or synthetic data may be used unless explicit written approval is granted. Do not store personally identifiable information (PII) on local device drives, personal equipment, or removable media (e.g., USB drives).
- AI must not infringe upon academic freedom or undermine autonomy; it should support—not dictate—pedagogical and research choices.
- Creating or distributing AI-generated or digitally altered images of others without consent is prohibited and may constitute bullying or cyberbullying.
- Unauthorized recording or photography using AI tools in locations with a reasonable expectation of privacy is prohibited.
- Each course syllabus must clearly state permitted and prohibited AI use (reference: AI Options for Course Syllabi).

Unacceptable Use:

- Connecting AI tools and resources to Southwest Tech enterprise applications without explicit approval by the AI Council.
- Use of AI tools and resources with Southwest Tech data without explicit approval of the tool by the AI Council.
- Using AI tools and resources to create any content that is illegal, discriminatory, defamatory, or otherwise offensive or inappropriate, or used to harass, bully, haze, intimidate, or discriminate.

- Sharing information of students, employees, or applicant information or other confidential or sensitive information with unauthorized individuals, including external parties that provide AI tools and resources.
- Engaging in any activity that could compromise the security or integrity of Southwest Tech using AI tools and resources systems, including attempting to open up access to unauthorized data sets and systems.
- Violating any applicable laws or regulations, including data protection and privacy laws using AI tools and resources.
- Accepting AI work product without appropriate and proper review and validation.
- Meeting recording agents may not be used to record meetings. If a meeting is recorded, the recording will need to be maintained for five (5) years as it is a public record.

Risks:

- **Data leakage.** Sending data to AI tools and resources that contain restricted, confidential and/or sensitive data could allow that data to be stored in a non-secure manner such as in logs, used to train other AI models, made publicly available, etc.
- **Introduction of vulnerabilities.** When used to generate code, AI tools and resources may provide vulnerabilities (ie, code, viruses, etc.)
- **Flawed algorithms/data.** Risk that crucial business decisions might be based on flawed algorithms, inaccurate data and/or bias.
- **Vulnerabilities.** As AI tools and resources gain popularity, imposter sites, applications, and plugins may be created. This may cause issues with malicious sites and man-in-the-middle traffic from the client to AI tools and resources to inspect questions and answers, and illegitimate sites to collect information.
- **Expanded cyber-threat.** The transformative nature of AI tools and resources hinges on the effectiveness of its security and privacy controls, but this is complicated due to:
 - To date, no industry standards to guide the secure development of AI systems and the AI marketplace does not focus on cyber-resilience.
 - Most AI companies are new and have not yet proven the security of their platforms or follow any industry specific standards or best practices.
 - Cybercriminals might exploit AI systems' self-learning capabilities, predict the data that are used to train algorithms and deliberately manipulate their behavior for malicious intent.

Continuous Risk Assessment and Change Management

- **Ongoing Risk Reviews:** AI tools and models must undergo periodic risk assessments to identify new vulnerabilities, compliance gaps, or ethical concerns as technology evolves.
- **Re-evaluation After Updates:** Any significant update or change to an AI tool must trigger a re-approval and risk review process.
- **Rapid Response Protocol:** A cross-functional AI Response Team will monitor industry developments and respond quickly to emerging threats, vulnerabilities, or regulatory changes.
- **Emergency Suspension:** The College reserves the right to immediately suspend or disable any AI tool or integration if new risks or misuse are detected.

Data Minimization and Protection

- **Limit Data Exposure:** Only the minimum necessary data should be shared with AI tools. Sensitive student or college data must be masked, anonymized, or excluded whenever possible.
- **Prohibition on Model Training:** Student, employee, and college data may not be used to train external or third-party AI models unless explicitly authorized by contract and reviewed by the AI Council.

Third-Party and Vendor Controls

- **Vendor Due Diligence:** Vendors providing AI solutions must demonstrate compliance with Southwest Tech’s security, privacy, and ethical standards. Contracts must include clear AI use, data handling, and incident response provisions.
- **Vendor Notification:** Vendors must notify Southwest Tech of any major changes to their AI products or services that could impact risk or compliance.

Reporting:

- Employees must report any suspected violations of this policy or misuse of this policy to the Executive Director of Information Technology Services and/or HR.
- Any incidents involving a potential threat or unintended use of college confidential information, involving the use of AI tools and resources, should be reported immediately to the Executive Director of Information Technology Services or HR.
- All reports of suspected violations or incidents will be investigated promptly and thoroughly.
- Employees who report suspected violations or incidents will be protected from any retaliation.
- The College reserves the right to review any usage or communications sent through AI tools and resources for the purpose of investigating suspected violations or incidents.
- Employees and students must cooperate fully with any investigations related to suspected violations or incidents where AI tools and resources have been applied.

3.0 – ACCOUNTABILITY, ENFORCEMENT AND AUDITING

3.1 Accountability

- The following table represents accountability categories, responsibility, cadence, and method of accountability the College will use to enforce AI use compliancy.

Area	Responsible Role	Cadence	Method
Acceptable Use	Executive Director ITS / AI Council	Annual + ongoing	AI tool approval, training, policy acknowledgment, monitoring
Auditing	ITS Security / Internal Audit	Quarterly	Log reviews, audit reports
Enforcement	HR + ITS Security	As needed (Single License Agreement defined)	Incident response workflow
Risk Assessment	AI Council	Quarterly	Risk register, tool reviews

Area	Responsible Role	Cadence	Method
Data Protection	Data Stewards + ITS Security	Continuous + annual review	DLP, access controls, audits

3.2 Enforcement

- Any user found to be in violation of this policy may be subject to Southwest Tech's disciplinary policies.
- Violations may result in suspension or loss of access to AI systems, disciplinary action, and potential civil or criminal consequences.
- Student behavioral and academic matters involving AI follow established **investigation**, sanction, and appeal procedures in the Student Code of Conduct.

3.3 Auditing

- Southwest Tech may perform random testing or review to ensure users are utilizing AI tools in accordance with this policy. As AI is a rapidly changing environment, the College will review this guidelines document on an annual basis or as needed to ensure it remains relevant, in line with the College's risk appetite and regulatory requirements. Any changes or updates to this policy will be communicated to all employees. The College reserves the right to make changes to this policy.
- Regular evaluations and audits of AI's impact and compliance will be conducted, with clear lines of responsibility for oversight.

4.0 – RAPID CHANGE AND EMERGING RISK CLAUSE

- Given the rapid evolution of AI technologies, this guidelines document will be updated as needed. The College reserves the right to immediately suspend use of any AI tool or practice if new risks, vulnerabilities, or regulatory requirements emerge.

5.0 - SUSTAINABILITY

Southwest Wisconsin Technical College approaches artificial intelligence with a focus on responsible, sustainable use that balances innovation with security, ethics, and long-term impact. AI is intended to support meaningful academic and operational outcomes—not frivolous or non-essential use—and must align with institutional priorities and compliance standards. The College emphasizes strong governance, data protection, and transparency, ensuring AI enhances—rather than replaces—human judgment while preserving trust and supporting sustainable institutional growth.

RELATED DOCUMENTS

AI options for Course Syllabi

[Student Code of Conduct 2025](#)

Employee Handbook

[Acceptable Use of Information Technology Resources 1.19.26.docx](#)